



Open Source antivirus

www.clamwin.com proves to be a must try antivirus, the ClamWin Ltd claims to have more than 6,00,000 users worldwide

Tomorrow's tux

Linux has come a long way over the past 20 years, but what will the next 20 years be like for it? Will 2012 finally be "The Year of the Linux Desktop" before the Mayans come to the future in their time machines and kill us all?

Kshitij Sobti

ksbitij.sobti@thinkdigit.com

Open source isn't just a geek term anymore, for good or for bad, open source has become mainstream and is generally considered a Good Thing™ by everyone, even those who don't have the faintest clue about what it means.

In the end, to the average user who doesn't know how to code, how is software whose code they won't download any better than software whose code they can't download?

Linux is everywhere

There is a boom of devices now, and we're faced with more computing platforms than we ever were before. We have smartphones, tablets and netbooks as

entirely new form factors, and they've brought with them special requirements, such as the need for a low power, customisable operating system, which Windows is not. On devices such as OLPC (one laptop per child) where there's an emphasis on reducing cost, Linux is just the right option, being most economical.

Microsoft has been slow to respond, and while there's a boom of ARM-based devices, it will be the next version of Windows, still far from release, which will feature ARM support. Debian GNU/Linux, on the other hand, has been available for as many as nine hardware platforms!

Android is Linux, Samsung's bada is Linux, Intel's MeeGo is Linux, Nokia's Maemo is Linux, HP's webOS is Linux, Amazon's Kindle runs Linux, and these are just some of the mobile operating systems. HP even wants to install webOS on printers.

Linux can be customized to the core, and this core has been to places you wouldn't believe, from watches to keyboards and digital cameras to weather balloons. It might not seem very beneficial to the average user that a company is using Linux to run their microwave, but the nature of the General Public License (GPL) is such that any advancements made by any company to Linux come back to Linux.

So where does Linux go next? Well,

everywhere! The Linux kernel has many places to go yet.

The desktop dream

Linux has been to every imaginative place, but on desktops it's still lagging

behind. Compare the statistics of Linux on PCs to Linux on specialized hardware and servers. On PCs, Linux is still hovering around 2 per cent, while on top 500 supercomputers, it has a share of over 90 per cent!

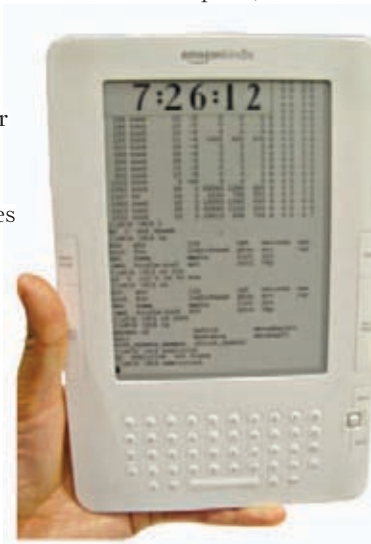
So is the Linux desktop dream dead? Far from it.

A larger number of people today are aware of Linux, many

of whom have used it at some point. Those who start off using netbooks have probably

used Linux, and probably won't be averse to using it again. However, schools are still mostly using Windows, and for most people that's where computers begin and end.

Linux is getting easier to use, despite the objections of ardent fans of the good old ways, and it's getting easier every



An Amazon Kindle running Ubuntu



Login from your mobile phone: Terminal running on Android



Malware too is moving online, and becoming platform-independent!